

Why Gender Matters For Labor Economics

Gender Study — Week 1

Teaching deck draft

Central question

- What makes gender a core labor-economics object rather than a single wage-gap statistic?
- The answer starts from labor objects: employment, hours, earnings, wages, occupations, firms, authority, safety, care, and welfare.
- Week 1 discipline: name the outcome, state the comparison, identify the mechanism, and choose the right measurement window.

Why this is a labor field

- Gender changes how workers allocate time, enter jobs, move across firms, receive pay, gain authority, face risk, and experience welfare.
- It connects Labor I objects: labor supply, family allocation, human capital, amenities, discrimination, and policy incidence.
- It connects Labor II objects: firms, search, wage-setting, contracts, regulation, internal labor markets, and worker voice.
- It is not only about wages, not only about women, and not only about discrimination.

Core labor-market objects

Object	Labor question
Employment	Who is attached to market work?
Hours and schedules	How much work is feasible, and when?
Wages and earnings	What is paid per hour, and what is earned over time?
Occupations and tasks	Where are workers allocated?
Firms and workplaces	Which firms hire, pay, promote, and retain?
Authority and promotion	Who controls resources, teams, and careers?
Safety and care	What risks and unpaid work shape the feasible set?
Welfare	What does work mean for utility, autonomy, and security?

Description starts with a gap

$$G_Y = \mathbb{E}[Y \mid F = 1] - \mathbb{E}[Y \mid F = 0]$$

- Y can be employment, hours, earnings, wages, promotion, authority, safety, or welfare.
- The statistic is useful for magnitude, trends, and comparisons.
- It is not a mechanism: the same gap can reflect supply, care, sorting, firms, bargaining, law, safety, or discrimination.

Why average gaps are incomplete

$$G = G^{prices} + G^{quantities} + G^{allocation}$$

Component	Interpretation
Prices	pay-setting, wage premia, returns, bargaining, discrimination
Quantities	hours, employment, experience, interruptions, attachment
Allocation	occupations, tasks, firms, supervisors, schedules, career ladders

- Conceptual point: an earnings gap is a bundle until the mechanism is named.

Mechanism classes

Class	Examples
Worker-side	skills, expectations, search, commuting, amenities, risk
Household-side	care work, fertility, bargaining, family formation
Firm-side	hiring, evaluation, pay-setting, promotion, authority, networks
Institutional	law, enforcement, norms, legal rights, workplace protections
Policy	childcare, leave, taxation, quotas, transparency, safety regulation

- Later weeks unpack these channels one at a time.

Measurement choices discipline claims

- Timing: entry, early career, family formation, mid-career, retirement.
- Family status: parents, nonparents, partnered workers, care responsibilities.
- Occupation and task: broad codes can hide authority, exposure, and schedules.
- Firm: workplace pay premia, promotion systems, supervisors, and climate.
- Legal environment: rights, restrictions, enforcement, eligibility, protections.
- Selection: wage data observe only workers with recorded jobs and pay.

Lifecycle timing and child penalties

$$Y_{it} = \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_k \mathbf{1}\{t - T_i = k\} + \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{it}$$

- T_i indexes a family event such as first birth.
- Event time asks when gaps open, not only whether a cross-sectional gap exists.
- The outcome can be employment, hours, earnings, wages, occupation, or firm assignment.
- Week 2 turns this into care, fertility, and household allocation.

$$Y_{if} = \alpha_i + \psi_f + \delta F_i + \varepsilon_{if}$$

- Firms allocate jobs, schedules, clients, training, bonuses, promotions, and authority.
- Worker sorting and firm behavior can both shape observed gender gaps.
- Authority gaps may persist even when wage gaps look smaller.
- Later weeks move into hiring, promotion, pay-setting, transparency, and leadership pipelines.

- Safety changes the feasible set of jobs, commutes, hours, occupations, and workplaces.
- Care work changes market labor supply, career timing, schedule constraints, and policy incidence.
- Welfare is broader than earnings: flexibility, security, autonomy, dignity, exposure, and nonmarket time matter.
- Standard payroll data often miss these objects, so measurement has to expand.

- Gendered laws affect access to work, mobility, assets, family decisions, safety, and workplace protections.
- Cross-country evidence is useful when it links legal objects to labor channels.
- Institutional measures must be interpreted carefully: the index is not itself the mechanism.
- Comparative settings help ask which mechanisms travel and which depend on development or labor-market structure.

Why this is a high-return research field

- Remaining disparities are large in employment, hours, earnings, careers, authority, safety, care, and welfare.
- The field links labor supply, firms, contracts, occupations, institutions, policy, and inequality.
- Data are rich: administrative panels, linked worker-firm records, legal datasets, time use, surveys, audits, job postings.
- Methods travel: decompositions, event studies, linked data, field experiments, and comparative institutional designs.
- Frontier questions remain abundant enough for dissertation-scale projects.

- Reproduce: synthetic country-year factbook inspired by gendered-laws evidence.
- Diagnose: outcome, comparison group, mechanism, level, and design type.
- Transfer: apply the same diagnostic logic to lifecycle child-penalty event time.
- Optional frontier prompt: how the question changes in worker-firm career data.

Bridge to Week 2

- Week 1 gives the full map of labor objects and measurement choices.
- Week 2 zooms in on labor supply, care work, fertility, and household allocation.
- Central next question: how do care responsibilities and family formation alter employment, hours, earnings, job choice, and welfare over the lifecycle?

Takeaways

- Gender is a core labor-economics field because it organizes work, pay, authority, risk, care, and welfare.
- Average gaps are necessary descriptions, but mechanisms require outcome choice, timing, and level of analysis.
- The course will move from objects to mechanisms to policy and frontier research design.